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THE BJP'S MUSLIM MODEL

Hindutva, the Politics of Exclusion and Why the BJP Still Wins Muslim Seats

I was waiting in Deputy Chief Minister Dinesh Sharma's antechamber in Lucknow. Also patiently awaiting their turn were at least two delegations of over fifty Muslim religious leaders, dressed in white kurta-pyjamas and prayer caps. Another delegation was already inside, closeted in conversation. I wondered why they were there. It was early June 2020. Perhaps it was because the state government had just announced that UP's mosques, which had been closed for two months due to the first COVID-induced national lockdown, could reopen but with 'wuzu' (hand-washing) now only allowed at home and no hugs or shaking of hands. These rules were similar to those for Hindu temples—which too could reopen, but with no bell-ringing, exchange of prasad, kirtans or bhajans, touching of gods and goddesses, or any footwear in the precincts. My colleagues and I got called inside for our interview before we could ask our fellow waiters in the antechamber why they had come. But such a large presence of Muslim notables in the deputy chief minister's office was a powerful visual metaphor for the big questions that have always been at the heart of the BJP's relationship with religion, its belief in Hindutva as a primary marker of Indianness, and the implications of this identity politics for India's Muslims.

So, I put two questions to Sharma at the end of our interview. How exactly does the BJP view Muslims? And how has it been